[13]
Satyameva Jayate?

With Regard to the Impending Execution of Mohammad Afzal Guru in Tihar Jail

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Shuddhabrata Sengupta

A few days from now, a man called Mohammad Afzal Guru, son of Habibullah Guru, currently resident in Ward Number 6 of Jail Number 1 in Tihar Central Prison in Delhi, will probably hang to satisfy the bloodlust of the Indian republic, unless the President of India thinks otherwise. A few weeks ago, I recall reading the NDTV newscaster Barkha Dutt's breathless three cheers (in NDTV Columns, 20 September 2006)[1] for the fact that India retains the death penalty (so that the indignant tears in the eyes of television presenters like herself, and the loved ones of murder victims, can be wiped away with each rope that tightens around the neck of condemned prisoners).[*]

At times like this, when hangmen are asked to practise their moves, nothing comes more handy than the Teflon-coated enthusiasm for capital punishment of television crusaders. Great democracies, like the United States of America, the Islamic republics of Iran and Pakistan, the People's Republic of China, the Democratic People's Republic of Korea and enlightened States like the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia are known for their zeal in retaining the death penalty as a necessary part of State ritual. The Republic of India is in eminent company, and I am grateful to Barkha Dutt for making me remember that. I need not advance moral and ethical arguments against the death penalty here, because they have been so well countered by Ms Dutt. Never mind the fact that States that have done away with the death penalty have lower rates of violent crime, never mind the fact that the innocence of people condemned to die has often been established after they have been executed. Ms Dutt has demonstrated that the death penalty is the balm that comforts her agonized soul. And many of those who argue that the President should not in fact assent